Specification of the controlled designation of origin "SAUTERNES"

Chapter I

I. – Name of the designation

Only wines meeting the specific provisions set out below may claim the controlled designation of origin "Sauternes", initially recognised by the decree of 30 September 1936.

II. – Geographical denominations and complementary terms

No specific provision.

III. – Colour and type of product

The controlled designation of origin "Sauternes" is reserved for still white wines.

IV. – Areas and zones in which the various operations are carried out

1° Geographical area:

The harvesting of the grapes, the vinification, the elaboration and the ageing of the wines are carried out within the territory of the following communes of the Gironde department, on the basis of the official geographic code dated 19 March 2021: Barsac, Bommes, Fargues, Preignac and Sauternes.

2° Delimited parcel area:

The wines come exclusively from vines situated within the delimited parcel production area as approved by the National Institute of Origin and Quality at the sessions of the competent national committee of 19 February 1986, 30 May 2007 and 5 November 2015.

The National Institute of Origin and Quality lodges with the town halls of the communes referred to in 1° the graphic documents establishing the parcel boundaries of the production area thus approved.

3° Immediate proximity area:

The immediate proximity area, defined by derogation for the vinification, the elaboration and the ageing, is made up of the territory of the following communes of the Gironde department, on the basis of the official geographic code dated 19 March 2021: Budos, Cadillac, Cérons, Escoussans, Gabarnac, Illats, Ladaux, Langon, Mazères, Monprimblanc, Omet, Pujols-sur-Ciron, Roaillan and Sainte-Croix-du-Mont.

V. – Grape varieties

The wines come from the following varieties: muscadelle B, sauvignon B, sauvignon gris G, sémillon B.

VI. – Management of the vineyard

1° Training methods:

a) Planting density.
The vines present a minimum planting density of 6,500 plants per hectare. The spacing between plants within the same row may not be less than 0.80 metre. The average spacing between rows may not be greater than 1.90 metre.

b) Pruning rules.
Pruning is carried out at the latest on 1 May. The vines are pruned according to the following techniques:

- muscadelle B variety: fan-trained, the stock, formed of 2 to 5 arms, bearing a maximum of 6 spurs pruned to two free eyes, with a maximum of 8 free eyes;

- sémillon B variety: fan-trained, the stock, formed of 2 to 5 arms, bearing a maximum of 6 spurs pruned to 2 free eyes, or mixed Guyot, with 6 free eyes at most on the long wood (cane) and two spurs pruned to 2 free eyes maximum, one being a return spur;

- sauvignon B and sauvignon gris G varieties: fan-trained, the stock, formed of 2 to 5 arms, bearing a maximum of 6 spurs pruned to 2 free eyes; mixed Guyot, with 6 free eyes at most on the long wood (cane) and two spurs pruned to 2 free eyes maximum, one being a return spur; Bordeaux pruning, the stock bearing two long woods (canes) with 4 free eyes maximum on each long wood.

c) Trellising rules and foliage height.
The height of the trellised foliage is at least equal to 0.5 times the spacing between rows, the height of trellised foliage being measured between the lower limit of the foliage and the upper topping limit.

d) Average maximum load per parcel.
- The average maximum load per parcel is fixed at 8,000 kilograms per hectare before over-ripening. - This load corresponds to a maximum of 12 bunches per plant.

e) Threshold for missing vines.
The percentage of dead or missing vine plants referred to in Article D. 645-4 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code is fixed at 20 %. Dead plants must be removed from the parcels; any storage of these dead plants on the parcels is prohibited.

f) Cultivation condition of the vine.
The parcels are managed so as to ensure a good overall cultivation condition of the vine, in particular the sanitary condition of the foliage and the upkeep of the soil. In particular, no parcel is left abandoned.

2° Other cultivation practices:

Any application of a plant-protection product with a specific anti-botrytis action is prohibited. Total chemical weeding of the parcels is prohibited. Every operator calculates and records its treatment frequency index (IFT).

VII. – Harvest, transport and ripeness of the grapes

1° Harvest:

a) The wines come from grapes harvested at over-ripeness (presence of noble rot).

b) Particular harvesting provisions. The wines come from grapes harvested manually by successive tries (selective pickings).

2° Ripeness of the grapes:

a) Sugar content of the grapes. Grapes with a sugar content of less than 221 grams per litre of must may not be considered to be at proper ripeness.

b) Minimum natural alcoholic strength by volume. The wines present a minimum natural alcoholic strength by volume of 15 %.

c) Minimum actual alcoholic strength by volume. The wines present a minimum actual alcoholic strength by volume of 12 %.

VIII. – Yields. – Entry into production

1° Yield:

The yield referred to in Article D. 645-7 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code is fixed at 25 hectolitres per hectare.

2° Limit yield:

The limit yield referred to in Article D. 645-7 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code is fixed at 28 hectolitres per hectare.

3° Entry into production of young vines:

The benefit of the controlled designation of origin may be granted to wines coming from:

- parcels of young vines only from the third year following that in the course of which planting was carried out in place before 31 July;

- parcels of young vines only from the second year following that in the course of which grafting in place was carried out before 31 July;

- parcels of vines that have been top-grafted, at the earliest in the second year following that in the course of which the top-grafting was carried out before 31 July, and once the parcels no longer contain any varieties other than those permitted for the appellation.

4° Coefficient K:

For wines produced on one and the same determined area of vines in production, only the controlled designations of origin “Sauternes” and “Bordeaux” may be claimed. In this case, the quantity declared under the controlled designation of origin “Bordeaux” must not be greater than the difference between that liable to be claimed under that appellation in accordance with Article D. 645-7 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code and that declared under the controlled designation of origin “Sauternes” to which a coefficient K is applied. The coefficient K is equal to the quotient obtained by dividing the yield established for the harvest in question for the controlled designation of origin “Bordeaux” by that of the controlled designation of origin “Sauternes”.

IX. – Processing, elaboration, ageing, packaging, storage

1° General provisions:

The wines are vinified in accordance with local, fair and constant usages.

a) Analytical standards. - Every lot of wine marketed (in bulk) or packaged presents a content of fermentable sugars (glucose and fructose) greater than or equal to 45 grams per litre. - Every lot of wine marketed presents a volatile acidity less than or equal to 25 milliequivalents per litre, or 1.5 gram per litre expressed as acetic acid (1.225 gram per litre expressed as H2SO4).

b) Oenological practices and physical treatments. Enrichment by dry sugaring or by rectified concentrated must may not have the effect of raising the total alcoholic strength by volume after enrichment beyond 15 %. Enrichment by partial concentration of the musts intended for the elaboration of wines is authorised within the limit of a concentration of 10 % of the volumes thus enriched. It may allow the total alcoholic strength by volume to be raised to a level of 21 % vol.

c) Prohibited equipment. - The use of the foulo-benne (self-emptying skip fitted with a so-called centrifugal paddle pump) is prohibited. - The use of the dynamic drainer, of the continuous-type press fitted with an endless screw of a diameter less than 400 mm, is prohibited.

d) Overall vat capacity. The overall capacity of the storage vat room (vats and casks) represents a minimum of twice the volume vinified.

e) Overall upkeep of the cellar and equipment. The cellar (floors and walls) and the vinification equipment present a good general condition of upkeep.

2° Provisions by type of product:

a) The wines are vinified and aged in an enclosed building specifically dedicated to these operations.

b) The wines undergo ageing at least until 15 March of the year following that of the harvest.

3° Provisions relating to packaging:

For each packaged lot, the operator keeps available for the defence and management body and for the approved control body:

- the information appearing in the register of handling operations referred to in Article D. 645-18 of the Rural and Maritime Fishing Code;

- an analysis carried out before or after packaging.

The analysis reports are kept for a period of six months from the date of packaging.

4° Provisions relating to storage:

The operator demonstrates a location suitable for the storage of the packaged products, inside the enclosed building referred to in point 2° above.

5° Provisions relating to the movement of products and to placing on the market for the consumer:

a) Date of placing on the market for the consumer. At the end of the ageing period, the wines are placed on the market for the consumer after 30 June of the year following that of the harvest.

b) Period during which the wines may not move between approved warehouse keepers. The wines may move between approved warehouse keepers at the earliest on 15 June of the year following that of the harvest.

X. – Link with the geographical area

1° – Information on the geographical area:

a) – Description of the natural factors contributing to the link:

The geographical area of the controlled designation of origin “Sauternes” is situated some forty kilometres to the south-east of Bordeaux. It lies on the left bank of the Garonne, encircling the commune of Langon to the north-west and west. To the west, it is separated from the Graves region and then very quickly from the forest of the Landes Girondines by the valley of the Ciron. This tributary of the Garonne, which forms the boundary of the communes of Sauternes, Bommes and Preignac, also separates the latter from Barsac. This appellation extends over 5 communes of the Gironde department (Barsac, Bommes, Fargues, Preignac and Sauternes).

The Sauternes region is the result of a long and complex geological history, closely linked to the birth of the Garonne, to the modifications of its course and to the successive glacial episodes of the Quaternary era. During these periods, the Pyrenean glaciers erode their valley and prepare the rocky stocks that the rivers would then roll as far as the estuary. Of these successive deposits, only relics remain in the form of gravelly-sandy knolls resting on a Tertiary limestone base found close to the surface especially at Barsac.

The soils of this region are diverse: gravelly, clayey, siliceous, calcareous, with marked alternations, and rest on a subsoil most often clayey but also gravelly or calcareous and sometimes made up of alios, a cementing of the sand grains and gravels by iron, aluminium and manganese hydroxides.

Situated at the heart of the Bordeaux area and benefiting from its oceanic climate, the Sauternes area presents climatic particularities. The mild and humid winters and the summers of moderate heat allow a slow ripening propitious to white grapes. The gentle hills of the various pedological terraces are situated along the axis of the Garonne valley in an east-south-east orientation favouring a good natural ventilation of the vineyard. At the same time, at the confluence of the “Ciron” and the “Garonne”, condensation phenomena bring abundant humidity. This alternation of night-time humidity and rapid and powerful daytime ventilation is at the origin of the invasion of the grapes by a tiny fungus, “Botrytis cinerea”, developing “noble rot” and the concentration of the grapes.

The Sauternes landscape, between river and forest, is made up of knolls covered with vines in close rows, bordered by dry-stone walls and punctuated by magnificent châteaux of all periods, since the 15th century, and by old villages of limestone.

b) – Description of the human factors contributing to the link:

The presence of the vine is attested in the Sauternes area from the Middle Ages. At the end of the 16th century and above all in the 17th century, maritime trade intensified. The provostship of Barsac, encompassing the present communes of the controlled designation of origin “Sauternes”, largely developed its renown. The texts of the period attest to it (the “usances et privilèges” of this cru in 1613, the “taxation of the wines” by the jurats of Bordeaux and the Dutch merchants in 1647).

It is at this period that most of the present crus developed. The Intendant of Guyenne wrote, as early as 1741, that there one harvests only "when the grapes are almost rotten", and that these harvests are made "several times over to give them more sweetness".

These practices became widespread in the 19th century to all the properties and Sauternes was adopted by the whole of Europe. This success is reflected in the 1855 classification of the wines of Bordeaux, by the brokers of the marketplace, for the Universal Exhibition at the initiative of the emperor Napoleon III. There, 27 classed growths are counted, the only white wines of the Gironde promoted in this classification.

The wines are elaborated mainly from sémillon B, a variety originating from the Sauternes area according to Georges Cazeaux-Cazalet, an expert in viticulture at the end of the 19th century. Its good resistance to downy mildew and to powdery mildew enabled it to resist and to dominate the local grape varieties very largely, ahead of sauvignon B, when these diseases threatened to destroy the vineyard at the end of the 19th century. This variety, with berries with thick skins, lends itself particularly well to botrytisation and to the production of great sweet wines. Sauvignon B, sauvignon gris G and muscadelle B often contribute to the grape varieties as they are sought after for their aromas.

The ripe grapes, covered by the fine down of the Botrytis, dry out gently under the combined effect of the sun and the wind. These conditions favour the concentrations of sugars and of characteristic aromatic compounds. The pickers then select with scissors these "roasted" grapes, plant by plant: this is the first trie. It is followed by two or three other tries, or more, decided according to the climatic alternations favouring the development of the fungus and the concentration of the grapes. The harvests are exclusively manual. The pressed grape then ferments very slowly, its richness leading to the stopping of the fermentation of the wines still charged with sugars, when the level of alcohol kills the yeasts.

The "Sauternes" appellation is recognised by decree on 30 September 1936, then instituting by regulation the local practices: art. 6 – The vinification must be made with grapes reaching over-ripeness (noble rot) harvested by successive tries.

The Sauternes vineyard, with an area in 2010 of more than 2,200 hectares, produces on average 41,000 hectolitres of wine, on around 190 independent holdings. The per-hectare yields are very low owing to the concentration of the grapes, and very variable between vintages.

2° – Information on the quality and characteristics of the product:

The wines of the controlled designation of origin "Sauternes" are still white wines with residual sugars. The characteristics of the wines of Sauternes are essentially due to the botrytisation of the grapes, the fungus causing biochemical transformations at the origin of specific olfactory and gustatory compounds, and of the concentration of sugars in the berries. Young, of a golden colour, they develop scents of flowers and fruits; then, on ageing, their colour turns amber and they develop their "roasted" bouquet, powerful aromas, notably grilled, of candied fruits, of citrus and of honey with a very great aromatic persistence. They are very unctuous and rich on the palate. These are wines of very long cellaring, of several decades, but like all great wines they are excellent from their bottling.

3° – Causal interactions:

The original climate offers particular mesoclimatic conditions that are at the origin of the development of a tiny fungus on the grape, "Botrytis cinerea", leading to "noble rot" which confers their typicity on the wines of the Sauternes area in this specific environment.

The wines come from parcels or parts of parcels that are the subject of a rigorous and precise delimitation resting on objective, technical and production-precedence criteria, on the proposal of a commission of independent experts.

People have selected over time the varieties best lending themselves to this botrytisation of the grapes; it is thus that sémillon B is said to originate from the Sauternes area.

Moreover, to reach the concentration sufficient for the elaboration of these wines, pruning is severe, specified for each of the varieties. A short pruning method specific to this region, fan pruning, is often used.

In order to attain excellence, the wines come from grapes harvested at over-ripeness (presence of noble rot), manually, by successive “tries”. Yields are very low after over-ripening, all the more so as the climatic conditions, variable according to the vintages, sometimes reduce the harvests drastically.

Planting densities are high because wine production per plant is very low after concentration. The fermentation of these wines is slow, often carried out in barrels. The wines undergo a long ageing before bottling, necessary for their refining and their better expression.

The renown of the wines of Sauternes was established early in history around emblematic châteaux, the most renowned of which, château d'Yquem, is known worldwide. The 1855 classification of the wines of Bordeaux, with the only “premier cru supérieur” awarded to château d'Yquem, 11 first growths and 15 second growths at Sauternes, very largely recognised the supremacy of this appellation in the Gironde. This classification took into account the prices reached by the wines because they reflected their quality.

Still today, their renown holds firm; the combination of an environment remarkably suited to the cultivation of the vine, of a particular microclimate and of the settling of pioneering wine-growers established practices specific to the obtaining of great sweet wines appreciated by connoisseurs the world over.

XI. – Transitional measures

1° Delimited parcel area:

The parcels planted with vines excluded from the delimited parcel area as defined in the present IV (2), identified by their cadastral references and their areas and the list of which was approved by the National Committee for wines, spirits and other alcoholic beverages of the National Institute of Origin and Quality at its session of 30 May 2007, continue to benefit, for their harvests, from the right to the controlled designation of origin “Sauternes” until their grubbing-up and at the latest until the 2025 harvest included, subject to meeting the other provisions of the present specification.

2° Areas and zones in which the various operations are carried out:

The operators known as vinifying and ageing their wines in communes situated outside the geographical area at the date of 31 July 2009 may continue these operations within the territory of these communes, until the 2020 harvest included, subject to compliance with the other provisions of the specification:

Operator	Commune
GUIGNAN Philippe	LE PIAN-SUR-GARONNE (Gironde)
SCEA Vignobles MASSIEU	SAINT-ANDRE-DU-BOIS (Gironde)

2° Training method:

a) Spacing between rows and distance between plants. The provisions relating to the spacing between rows and to the distance between plants within the same row do not apply to vines in place at the date of 31 July 2009.

b) Planting density.

SITUATION OF THE PARCELS	RULE TO BE OBSERVED, subject to compliance with the other provisions of the present specification
Parcels of vines in place at the date of 31 July 2009 situated off clay slopes	Parcels of vines whose planting density is less than 6,500 plants per hectare and greater than or equal to 5,000 plants per hectare continue to benefit, for their production, from the right to the controlled designation of origin until their grubbing-up. Parcels of vines whose planting density is less than 5,000 plants per hectare continue to benefit, for their production, from the right to the controlled designation of origin until their grubbing-up and at the latest until the 2014

SITUATION OF THE PARCELS	RULE TO BE OBSERVED, subject to compliance with the other provisions of the present specification
	harvest included. Parcels of vines whose planting density, reduced by the percentage of dead or missing plants fixed in the present specification, is less than 5,200 plants per hectare are the subject of a yield reduction calculated from the ratio between the number of dead or missing plants and the density of 6,500 plants per hectare.
Parcels of vines in place at the date of 31 July 2009 situated on clay slopes *Clay slopes are characterised by a slope greater than or equal to 5 % and a clay content greater than or equal to 30 %.*	Parcels of vines whose planting density is less than 6,500 plants per hectare and greater than or equal to 5,000 plants per hectare continue to benefit, for their production, from the right to the controlled designation of origin until their grubbing-up. Parcels of vines whose planting density is less than 5,000 plants per hectare continue to benefit, for their production, from the right to the controlled designation of origin until their grubbing-up and at the latest until the 2014 harvest included. Parcels of vines whose planting density, reduced by the percentage of dead or missing plants fixed in the present specification, is less than 4,000 plants per hectare are the subject of a yield reduction calculated from the ratio between the number of dead or missing plants and the density of 5,000 plants per hectare.

c) Trellising and foliage height. The trellising and foliage-height rules apply, for the vines in place at the date of 31 July 2009, from the 2015 harvest included.

XII. – Rules of presentation and labelling

1° General provisions:

Wines for which, under the terms of the present specification, the controlled designation of origin “Sauternes” is claimed and which are presented under the said appellation may not be declared after the harvest, offered to the public, dispatched, put up for sale or sold unless, in the harvest declaration, in advertisements, on leaflets, labels, invoices and any containers whatsoever, the aforesaid controlled designation of origin is entered.

2° Particular provisions:

The larger geographical unit “Vin de Bordeaux” or “Grand Vin de Bordeaux” may appear on the labels, leaflets and any containers. The dimensions of the characters of this larger geographical unit are not greater, both in height and in width, than two thirds of those of the characters composing the name of the controlled designation of origin.

Chapter II

I. – Declaration obligations

1° Prior declaration of parcel assignment:

Each operator declares to the defence and management body the list of parcels assigned to the production of the controlled designation of origin before 1 January preceding the harvest. This declaration is renewable by tacit renewal, save for changes notified by the operator before 1 January preceding each harvest. This declaration specifies:

- the identity of the operator;

- its EVV or SIRET number;

- for each parcel: the cadastral reference, the area, the year of planting, the variety, the planting density, the spacings within the row and between rows.

2° Claim declaration:

The claim declaration is sent to the defence and management body before 15 December of the year following that of the harvest.

It indicates:

- the designation claimed;

- the volume of the wine;

- the EVV or SIRET number;

- the name and address of the applicant;

- the place of storage of the wine.

It is accompanied by a copy of the harvest declaration and, as the case may be, a copy of the production declaration or an extract of the stock accounts for buyers of grapes and musts.

3° Prior declaration of removals or packaging:

Every operator wishing to move or package wines benefiting from the controlled designation of origin declares to the approved control body any bulk removal or packaging operation at least five working days before the operation.

Chapter III

I – Main points to be checked and evaluation methods

MAIN POINTS TO BE CHECKED	EVALUATION METHODS
A. – STRUCTURAL RULES	
A1. – Belonging of the planted parcels to the delimited area	Documentary check (up-to-date CVI record) and check in the field
A2. – Claimable production potential (grape varieties, planting density and trellising, transitional measures, abandoned vines)	Documentary check and check in the field.
A3. – Processing, ageing, packaging and storage facilities	
Holdings vinifying outside the area.	Documentary check.
Traceability of packaging.	Documentary check (register keeping) and on-site check.
Enclosed building specifically dedicated to the vinification, elaboration, ageing and storage operations.	Documentary check and on-site check.
B. – RULES LINKED TO THE PRODUCTION CYCLE	
B1. – Management of the vineyard. — Pruning.	Counting of the number of free eyes (buds) per plant and description of the pruning method.
Average maximum load per parcel.	Counting of bunches and estimation of the load.
Cultivation condition of the vine.	Check at the parcel.
B2. – Harvest, transport and ripeness of the grapes. — Manual harvest by successive tries.	Check at the parcel.
Ripeness of the grapes.	Verification of the records (maturity controls) at the operators'.

B3. – Processing, elaboration, ageing, packaging, storage. — Oenological practices or treatments (enrichment).	Documentary check and on-site check.
B4. – Harvest declaration and claim declaration. — Missing vines.	Documentary check (up-to-date list kept by the operator) and check in the field.
Authorised yield.	Documentary check (check of declarations, yield increase for certain operators).
VSI, volumes harvested in excess of the authorised yield.	Documentary check (monitoring of destruction certificates).
Claim declaration.	Documentary check and on-site check (compliance with the arrangements and deadlines).
C. – CHECKS ON THE PRODUCTS	
Non-packaged wines (at removal).	Analytical and organoleptic examination.
Packaged wines.	Analytical and organoleptic examination.
Non-packaged wines intended for a dispatch outside the national territory.	Analytical and organoleptic examination of all the lots.
D. – PRESENTATION OF THE PRODUCTS	
Labelling.	Documentary check and on-site check.

II – References concerning the control structures

National Institute of Origin and Quality (I.N.A.O)
TSA 30003
93555 – MONTREUIL-SOUS-BOIS Cedex
Tel: (33) (0)1.73.30.38.00
Fax: (33) (0)1.73.30.38.04
Email: info@inao.gouv.fr

The control of compliance with the present specification is carried out by a third-party body offering guarantees of competence, impartiality and independence, under the authority of the INAO, on the basis of an approved inspection plan.

The inspection plan sets out the self-checks carried out by the operators on their own activity and the internal checks carried out under the responsibility of the defence and management body. It indicates the external checks carried out by the third-party body as well as the analytical and organoleptic examinations. All the checks are carried out by sampling. Non-packaged wines intended for a dispatch outside the national territory are the subject of a systematic analytical and organoleptic check.

The control of compliance with the present specification is carried out on the basis of an approved control plan and by a third-party body offering guarantees of competence, impartiality and independence and having received delegation from the INAO. The control plan sets out the self-checks carried out by the operators on their own activity and the internal checks carried out under the responsibility of the defence and management body. It indicates the external checks carried out by the third-party body as well as the analytical and organoleptic examinations. All the checks are carried out by sampling. Non-packaged wines intended for a dispatch outside the national territory are the subject of a systematic analytical and organoleptic check.